Chapter One

Civil War, 1947-1948

"If such a state is to be established, it can only be established over our dead bodies."

—Efraim Karsh

The confusion about what was to happen in Palestine in May 1948 led to heightened tensions in the region. These rapidly escalated into full-scale armed confrontations between Jews and Arabs within Palestine. Britain had already started to reduce the number of troops in the area and generally refused to intervene. Palestine quickly descended into something approaching full-scale civil war.

Israeli settlers had already created a number of armed groups with the purpose of fighting British rule in Mandatory Palestine. With the announcement that Britain planned to withdraw from the region in 1948, these groups switched their focus to preparing to fight Arab nationalists instead. The largest and most important of these groups was Haganah ("the Defense"), a paramilitary formed in 1920. By 1947, Haganah was thought to comprise up to 30,000 armed troops.

Irgun, a smaller but more militant faction, had broken off from Haganah in 1936 (it was Irgun that was responsible for the bombing of the King David Hotel in 1946). Lehi, another small group, was founded in 1940 by former members of Irgun and pursued its own agenda that originally included terrorist attacks on British forces and, bizarrely, an attempt to form an alliance with Nazi Germany in the early years of World War II. By 1947, Irgun and Lehi could call on around 3,000 armed troops in total.

It was during this fateful year of 1947 that Haganah, previously a clandestine organization, came into the open as the main defense force for Jewish settlements in Palestine. It introduced a new command structure that included three distinct groups: the Field Corps, the Guard Corps, and the Palmach strike force. Tensions in